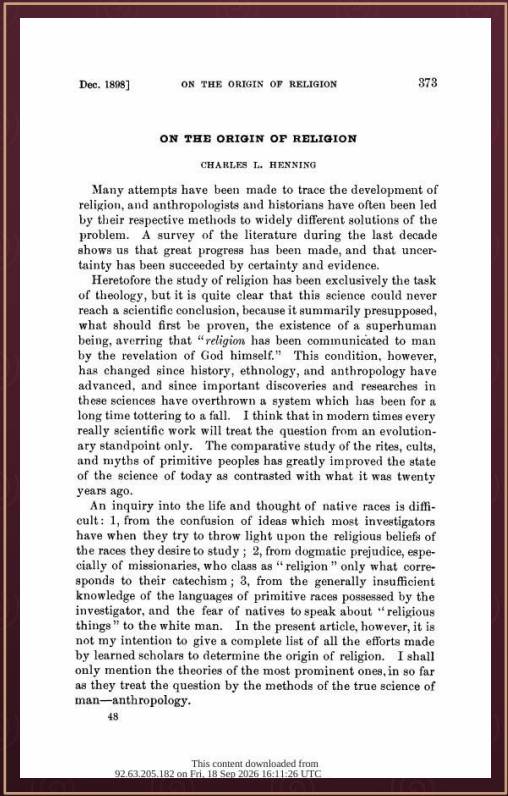
RESEARCH ARTICLE PRESENTATION

ON THE ORIGIN OF RELIGION

CHARLES L. HENNING · 1898

American Anthropologist, Vol. 11, No. 12, pp. 373–382

CONTEXT



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ON THE ORIGIN OF RELIGION

CHARLES L. HENNING

Many attempts have been made to trace the development of religion, and anthropologists and historians have often been led by their respective methods to widely different solutions of the problem. A survey of the literature during the last decade shows us that great progress has been made, and that uncertainty has been succeeded by certainty and evidence.

Heretofore the study of religion has been exclusively the task of theology, but it is quite clear that this science could never reach a scientific conclusion, because it summarily presupposed, what should first be proven, the existence of a superhuman being, averring that "*religion* has been communicated to man by the revelation of God himself." This condition, however, has changed since history, ethnology, and anthropology have advanced, and since important discoveries and researches in these sciences have overthrown a system which has been for a long time tottering to a fall. I think that in modern times every really scientific work will treat the question from an evolutionary standpoint only. The comparative study of the rites, cults, and myths of primitive peoples has greatly improved the state of the science of today as contrasted with what it was twenty years ago.

An inquiry into the life and thought of native races is difficult: 1, from the confusion of ideas which most investigators have when they try to throw light upon the religious beliefs of the races they desire to study; 2, from dogmatic prejudice, especially of missionaries, who class as "religion" only what corresponds to their catechism; 3, from the generally insufficient knowledge of the languages of primitive races possessed by the investigator, and the fear of natives to speak about "religious things" to the white man. In the present article, however, it is not my intention to give a complete list of all the efforts made by learned scholars to determine the origin of religion. I shall only mention the theories of the most prominent ones, in so far as they treat the question by the methods of the true science of man—anthropology.

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The anthropologist

Charles L. Henning published this in American Anthropologist (1898), then the journal of the Anthropological Society of Washington. Little is known about his life.

The “field”: no fieldwork

An armchair study. Henning compared reports by missionaries, travellers and scholars on peoples in Africa, India and North America, and on ancient Egypt and Syria.

Why I chose this article

It asks one of the biggest questions of our topic, where religion comes from, and shows how anthropology worked at its very beginning.

RESEARCH QUESTION

“How did primitive man obtain conceptions that we call ‘religious’?”
Henning, 1898, p. 376

THEORIES HE CHALLENGES

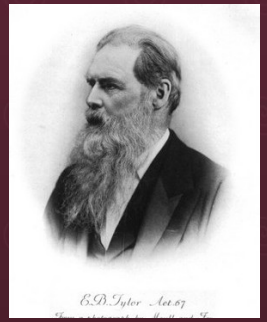
E. B. Tylor: animism, “the belief in spiritual beings”

J. Lippert: religion began as soul worship

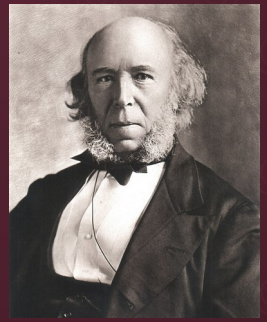
H. Spencer: ancestor worship is the root of every religion

A. Lefèvre: “anthropism”: giving human qualities to nature

His critique: a “soul” or “spirit” needs advanced thinking, so it cannot be the first step. And all these theories ignore one factor: **economic conditions.**



E. B. Tylor
Primitive Culture (1871)



Herbert Spencer
Principles of Sociology

THE FIELD: PLACES IN HIS SOURCES



Herero · Namibia

The chief's grave is the most sacred place; people ask his soul for advice.



San · Kalahari

Prayer to Cagn: "Don't you see our hunger? Give us to eat!"



Zulu · South Africa

Ancestors are worshipped; Unkulunkulu, "the Old, Old One", was the first man.



Tlingit · NW Coast

The hero Yehl first taught them how to improve their life.



Ancient Egypt

Osiris and Isis taught farming, bread-making and weaving.

Also used: *the Khonds of Orissa (India), the Zuñi (New Mexico) and Baal in ancient Syria. Henning never visited these places; he read about them.*

FINDINGS I: ECONOMY COMES FIRST

“Primitive man had no religion.” Henning, 1898, p. 377



Key claim: religion is not an inborn “religious sentiment”. It developed later, out of economic and social life.

FINDINGS II: FROM BENEFACTORS TO GODS

A few people improve the group's life

▼

After death: remembered as "heroes" or "benefactors"

▼

Ancestor worship

▼

Soul worship and later religion

Root of it all: economic conditions

Evidence in the prayers

Prayers ask for food, safety and good harvests. A Khond prayer (India) names "*the connection between our wealth and your honor*".

His definition of religion

"*The conception man forms of his relations to the superhuman and mysterious powers on which he believes himself to depend.*" (p. 382)

Limits he admits

Not yet proven for all peoples; ethnographers usually stay only a short time with one group.

CONNECTION WITH OUR COURSE

Cultural evolutionism

Like Tylor and Spencer, Henning imagines one ladder from “primitive” to “civilized”. Boas and later anthropologists rejected this model.

Armchair vs. fieldwork

He used second-hand reports. Today we expect long-term fieldwork and participant observation: religion seen from the inside.

Ethnocentrism

Words like “savage” and “primitive” judge others by Western standards. This shows why cultural relativism matters.

Religion, economy & society

Ancestor veneration, morality and making a living are linked: religion can help a group survive and stay together.

MY REFLECTIONS & LET'S DISCUSS

MY REFLECTIONS

Surprising: his confident claim that the first humans had no religion, with almost no direct evidence.

Interesting: the prayers are so practical ("Give us to eat!"). Belief and everyday life are still linked today.

Learned: how far anthropology has come, from desk theories and "savages" to fieldwork and respect.

LET'S DISCUSS

1. Think of a prayer, holiday or ritual in your culture. Is it linked to food, work or wealth? Is religion only about material needs?

2. Henning never met the people he wrote about. How might his ideas change after a year living with the Herero or the Zulu?

Pair activity (2 min): name someone honoured because they improved others' lives. How is their memory kept? Is it "religious"?

REFERENCE

Henning, C. L. (1898). On the origin of religion. *American Anthropologist*, *11*(12), 373–382. https://www.jstor.org/stable/658576

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